

Mesosphere

The top of the mesosphere is the coldest part of the Earth's atmosphere, with temperatures of -143°C (-226°F). Gases here are thick enough to slow down meteors, causing them to burn up.

Stratosphere

The air in this layer is very dry and still. The ozone layer, which protects plants and animals on Earth from dangerous ultraviolet (UV) rays that are given off by the Sun, lies in the stratosphere.

Troposphere

The gases found in the troposphere make up the air that we breathe. Therefore, life exists in this layer. Clouds form here, and it is where most of our weather occurs.

Planes

Planes usually fly in the troposphere, but may go up to the edge of the stratosphere.

Mountains

Some of Earth's highest mountains extend quite a way into the troposphere.

Ozone layer

This thin band, running across the stratosphere, contains a large amount of ozone, a gas that absorbs ultraviolet (UV) rays from the Sun. UV rays cause sunburn, and can cause skin cancer.

Reflected rays

Weather balloons

Scientists launch these to collect information about conditions in Earth's atmosphere that affect the weather, such as temperature and air pressure.

Meteors

These are bits of matter from outer space that burn up on entering Earth's atmosphere, creating streaks of light. They are also called shooting stars.

Sun's rays

50-80

16-50

0-16

DISTANCE FROM EARTH IN KILOMETRES